

The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called 'Buddha-Nature'

Āryatathāgatagarbha-nāma-mahāyānasūtra · Toh 258 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ད་བཞུགས་གཤམ་པའི་སྤྱི་པ་ཞེས་བ་བྱ་ཐག་པ་ཆེ་པའི་མཛོད་

Toh 258 in the Kangyur is a Mahāyāna sūtra known in Sanskrit as the Āryatathāgatagarbha-nāma-mahāyānasūtra, in Tibetan as the Phags pa de bzhin gshegs pa'i snying po zhes bya ba theg pa chen po'i mdo, and in English as the Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called "Buddha-Nature." It belongs to the class of tathāgatagarbha literature, which concerns the teaching that all sentient beings possess within them an innate buddha-nature — the seed or essence of awakening — and it is one of the earliest and most foundational texts to articulate this doctrine explicitly. The sūtra is set at Vulture Peak Mountain in Rājagṛha, where the Buddha, ten years after his enlightenment, addresses a vast assembly of monks and bodhisattvas and uses a series of vivid similes to illustrate how buddha-nature is present in all beings even while obscured by adventitious defilements. As Toh 258 in the Kangyur, it is classified among the general Mahāyāna sūtras and has exercised a profound and lasting influence on Buddhist thought across Tibet, China, and East Asia.

In the language of India: Āryatathāgatagarbha-nāma-mahāyānasūtra. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called "Buddha-Nature" (tathāgatagarbha).

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, when the Blessed One had been fully and perfectly awakened for ten years, and it was the height of summer, he was dwelling at Rājagṛha on Vulture Peak Mountain, in a magnificent jeweled palace-pavilion with a chamber built of heartwood sandalwood. With him was a great Saṅgha of monks — fully ordained monks who were śrāvakas, both those in training and those beyond training — complete in number to one hundred thousand, the great majority of whom were arhats: their defilements exhausted, free from afflictions, endowed with mastery, utterly liberated in mind, utterly liberated in wisdom, who had come to know all things, great elephants, who had done what had to be done, accomplished what had to be accomplished, laid down their burden, attained their own highest good, utterly exhausted all bonds to continued existence, and whose minds were utterly liberated through perfect knowledge — every single one of them having gone

beyond the supreme shore of the highest faculty among all sentient beings. They were as follows: the venerable Mahākāśyapa, the venerable Uruvilā-Kāśyapa, the venerable Nadī-Kāśyapa, the venerable Gayā-Kāśyapa, the venerable Mahākātyāyana, the venerable Mahāgavāmpatī, the venerable Bakula, the venerable Gavāṃpati, the venerable Subhūti, the venerable Pūrṇa son of Maitrāyaṇī, the venerable Vākīśvara, the venerable Śāriputra, the venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana, the venerable Ajñāta-Kauṇḍinya, the venerable Śvāpāda, the venerable Rāhula, the venerable Nanda, the venerable Upananda, the venerable Ānanda — together with these and the rest, the full assembly of one hundred thousand monks.

Also gathered there from different buddha-fields were bodhisattvas, great bodhisattvas — every one of them, numbering as many as the grains of sand of sixty Gaṅgā rivers, bound by but one more birth, possessed of great superknowledges, of powers and fearlessness, who had paid homage to many tens of millions of billions of buddhas, who had set the irreversible wheel of Dharma rolling — and the mere hearing of whose names was enough to render the immeasurable and incalculable sentient beings of countless world-spheres irreversible from unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. They were as follows: the bodhisattva great bodhisattva Dharmamati, Siṃhamati, Vyāghramati, Arthamati, Ratnamati, Viśeṣamati, Candraprabhā, Ratnacandraprabhā, Candramasā-matsyāprabhā, Mahāvikramin, Apramitavikramin, Anantavikramin, Trailokyavikramin, Acalavikramin, Maharddhiprāpta, Avalokiteśvara, Gandhahastī, Gandhaprīta, Gandhaprīyaśrī, Śrīgarbha, Ādityagarbha, Ketu, Mahāketu, Vimalaketu, Ratnanantadaṇḍa, Ratnadaṇḍaviśārada, Ratnavimaṇadaṇḍa, Paramaprīyarāja, Sadāpramuditā, Ratnapāṇi, Ākāśagarbha, Parvata, Sumeru, Mahāparvata, Guṇaratnābhā, Dhāraṇīśvararāja, Dharaṇidhara, Sarvasattvarogapraśamana, Supramuditā, Daurmanasya, Adaurmanasya, Prabhākara, Candana, Calanapratīṣedha, Apramitādhyuṣitasvaramandita,

Bodhicittodgama, Arthādarśana, Sarvadharmavaśavartana — and the great bodhisattvas Maitreya and Mañjuśrī, the Ever-Youthful — together with all those and other great bodhisattvas as numerous as the grains of sand in sixty Ganges rivers. Together with them also were immeasurable gods (devas), nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, and beings both human and non-human, beyond counting.

Then the Blessed One, surrounded by many hundreds of thousands in his retinue and facing forward, was venerated, honoured, revered, and

worshipped by kings, great ministers, merchants, householders, officials, citizens, and the people of the land. At that time, following the midday meal, the Blessed One entered into perfect meditative equipoise within that very many-storied sandalwood pavilion.

Then, by the power of the buddhas, from that many-storied sandalwood pavilion there arose lotuses possessing ten billion petals and ten trillion petals, each as large as the wheel of a cart, adorned with colours and hues numbering in the ten billions and hundred billions. These rose up and filled the entire sky above, covering this buddha-field perfectly endowed with all qualities, spreading everywhere like a canopy of precious jewels. And within each lotus calyx a Tathāgata sat cross-legged, radiating hundreds of light-rays in all directions; and all those lotuses opened wide and fully.

Then, by the blessing of the buddhas, all the petals of those lotuses became withered, shrivelled, foul-smelling, contemptible, and stripped of all delight. Yet within those same lotus calyxes the forms of the Tathāgatas continued to sit cross-legged, radiating hundreds of light-rays in all directions with magnificent brilliance. The forms of the Tathāgatas seated within the lotus calyxes pervaded this entire buddha-field perfectly endowed with all qualities, and at that moment this buddha-field became supremely beautiful.

Then at that time the entire assembly of bodhisattvas and all four groups of the retinue were filled with wonder and great joy. Seeing this miraculous display performed by the Blessed One, they fell into doubt, thinking: "These lotuses — tens of billions, hundreds of billions in number — have petals of ugly colour, and their filaments too are ugly in colour and worthy only of contempt, not fit to inspire delight. And yet within those very lotus calyxes, one Tathāgata in each sits cross-legged, radiating hundreds of light-rays, and all appear with magnificent beauty. What is the cause of this? What is the condition?"

Then the entire assembly of bodhisattvas and the four groups of the retinue, overcome by doubt, made a sign that they wished to approach. At that moment, a great bodhisattva named Vajramati had gathered and was seated within that many-storied sandalwood pavilion. The Blessed One then addressed the great bodhisattva Vajramati:

"Son of good family, take up the matter as a topic of Dharma discourse and summon the courage to put a thorough question to the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened buddha."

Then the great bodhisattva Vajramati, having received permission from the Blessed One, and being aware of the thorn of doubt that pierced the world with its gods, humans, and asuras, all the bodhisattvas, and the four groups of the retinue, addressed the Blessed One in these words: "Blessed One, what is the cause and what is the condition that this entire world-system is covered by these many hundreds of millions of lotuses with ugly coloring and foul odor such as these, and that amid them the Tathāgatas are seated cross-legged, radiating hundreds of thousands of rays of light on every side, and that upon seeing those forms of the Tathāgata, many hundreds of millions of living beings join their palms and make prostration?"

Then at that moment the bodhisattva Vajramati spoke these verses:

Tens of millions of buddhas, unmoving,
seated amidst the lotuses —
such a miraculous display as this you show,
and I have never before seen anything like it.

Sending forth a thousand rays of light,
filling all these buddha-fields —
O guides who delight in wondrous Dharma,
may you leave no question unanswered.

Amid these lotuses with despicable petals
and stems fit only for contempt,
with their ugly coloring — there in their midst
they are seated, like the nature of precious jewels.

For what purpose have these miracles been manifested?
I have seen buddhas as numerous as the sands of the Gaṅgā,
and their extraordinary miracles I have beheld —
yet such an emanation as appears today
I have never seen before, not even once.

O foremost of bipeds, may the god please reveal this.
May the cause and condition be explained.
May you speak with compassion for the welfare of the world.
May you cut through the doubt of all embodied beings.

Then the Blessed One addressed the great bodhisattva Vajramati and the entire assembly of bodhisattvas gathered there: "Sons of good family, there is a sūtra of great extent called 'The Tathāgatagarbha' (buddha-nature). It is in

order to fully reveal that teaching that the Tathāgata has produced this such-like luminous sign. Therefore listen well, take it to heart, and I shall explain."

The great bodhisattva Vajramati and the entire assembled host of bodhisattvas replied to the Blessed One, "Excellent!" and listened as the Blessed One directed. Then the Blessed One spoke thus:

"Sons of good family, just as gods and humans, upon perceiving those emanated lotuses of the Tathāgata — ugly in color, foul in odor, fit only for contempt, incapable of giving delight — together with those beautiful, fine, and lovely forms of the Tathāgata seated cross-legged at the heart of those lotuses, radiating hundreds of thousands of rays of light, bow down in reverence and perform acts of offering — in precisely the same way, sons of good family, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened buddha, with his own wisdom, his gnosis, and the eye of the Tathāgata, looks upon all sentient beings who have become living creatures and who are contained within a shell of hundreds of millions of afflictions — attachment, aversion, delusion, craving, and ignorance. Sons of good family, within those sentient beings enclosed in the shell of afflictions there abides one endowed with gnosis just like mine —

sees the many Tathāgatas, possessed of eyes, seated cross-legged and abiding without moving. Having seen within those afflicted ones the nature of reality of the Tathāgata — unmoved, unstained by all the migrations of existence — those Tathāgatas declare, "They are like me." Sons of good family, such is the beauty of the Tathāgata's eye: by that Tathāgata's eye, all sentient beings are seen to possess the tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature).

Sons of good family, consider this further analogy. A certain person possessed of divine sight, gazing with his divine eye, beholds lotuses of ill color and foul odor, their petals not yet opened or spread wide. Perceiving that within their centers Tathāgatas sit cross-legged in meditation, he desires to behold those forms of the Tathāgata. And so, in order to reveal the forms of the Tathāgatas clearly, he peels away and removes those petals of ill color and foul odor, which are worthy of contempt. In precisely the same way, sons of good family, the Tathāgata too, seeing all sentient beings with the buddha's eye to possess the tathāgatagarbha, teaches the Dharma in order to split open the shell of afflictions — attachment, aversion, delusion, clinging to existence, and ignorance — that encloses those sentient beings. In accomplishing this, those

Tathāgatas remain in perfect reality.

Sons of good family, this is the nature of reality of all phenomena: whether Tathāgatas arise or do not arise, these sentient beings are forever possessed of the tathāgatagarbha. Sons of good family, because those beings are shrouded in a shell of afflictions worthy of contempt, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened buddha teaches the Dharma to bodhisattvas in order to break that shell of afflictions and to fully purify the tathāgata-gnosis as well, and inspires them toward this endeavor. When those bodhisattvas, great beings, who dwell in earnest devotion to these teachings, become fully liberated from all afflictions and secondary afflictions, they come to be counted among those called Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha, and they perform all the activities of a Tathāgata.

Then at that time the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Just as a lotus worthy of contempt,
its petals wrapped close, not yet spread wide,
holds within it, unstained, the tathāgatagarbha —
seen by one in whom a divine eye abides.

When he parts those petals open wide,
he sees within the Victor's body shining clear.
From that moment, the Victor's secondary afflictions form no more —
and he becomes victorious throughout all the world.

Just so, I behold within all living creatures
the body of the Victors dwelling at their core,
covered over by billions upon thousands of millions of afflictions
like the shell of a contemptible lotus.

And so, in order to reveal them clearly,
I teach the Dharma continually to the wise,
cleansing afflictions for the sake of the Victor —
knowing that these sentient beings shall become buddhas.

My buddha-eye is like this:
with it I behold all sentient beings
dwelling in the body of the Victor,
and I teach the Dharma in order to purify them.

Sons of good family, consider yet another analogy. Imagine a round beehive hanging from the branch of a tree, protected on all sides by a hundred

thousand bees and full to the brim with honey. Then a person desiring that honey, through skillful means, drives away the living creatures — those bees — and the honey thereupon performs the function of honey.

Sons of good family, in just the same way, all sentient beings are like that beehive. With the Tathāgata's wisdom one perceives and understands that buddhahood itself, within them, is guarded on all sides by hundreds of thousands of millions of afflictions and secondary afflictions.

Sons of good family, just as a wise and skilled person, knowing that within the beehive there is honey guarded on all sides by hundreds of thousands of millions of bees, perceives and understands that fact — in the same way, with the Tathāgata's wisdom one perceives and understands that within all sentient beings there exists buddhahood, guarded on all sides by hundreds of thousands of millions of afflictions and secondary afflictions.

Sons of good family, and in that regard, just as the Tathāgata, skilled in means, drives away the bees — in the same way he removes from those sentient beings the afflictions and secondary afflictions: attachment, aversion, delusion, pride, conceit, concealment, anger, malice, envy, avarice, and all such afflictions and secondary afflictions. He teaches the Dharma in whatever way ensures that those sentient beings will not come to be afflicted by those afflictions and secondary afflictions, and will not be harmed by them. Having thus purified the vision of the Tathāgata's wisdom, he performs the activity of a Tathāgata in the world. Sons of good family, it is with my perfectly pure tathāgata-eye that I behold all sentient beings in exactly this way.

Then at that time the Blessed One declared these verses:

Just as there is here a beehive
guarded and hidden on all sides by bees —
a man who desires the honey, seeing it,
proceeds to drive the bees away entirely —

so too here, like a beehive,
are all sentient beings throughout the three realms of existence.
They are shrouded by many hundreds of millions of afflictions,
yet in the midst of those afflictions the Tathāgata is seen to dwell.

I too, for the sake of fully purifying the buddhas,
remove the afflictions as one drives away the bees —
teaching the Dharma here through skillful means

to those who would be harmed by millions of afflictions —

so that they, having become Tathāgatas,
may forever perform the activity of a Tathāgata throughout all worlds,
and so that those endowed with confidence may teach the Dharma
in a vessel fit to hold the honey of the bees.

Sons of good family, consider yet another analogy. Take rice, or śāli grain, or cīṇaka millet, or barley — any of these grains is completely enclosed and protected by its husk. So long as it has not been removed from its own husk, the grain cannot perform the function of food, of cooked fare, or of something to be eaten. Sons of good family, and yet men and women who desire it as food, as cooked fare, or for whatever purpose of eating and drinking — they thresh and pound it and thereby strip away the inner husk and the outer shell.

Sons of good family, in just the same way, the Tathāgata, with the eye of a Tathāgata, beholds in all sentient beings the very nature of a Tathāgata, buddhahood, self-arisen reality — wrapped and dwelling within the shell of the husk of afflictions.

Sons of good family, and in that regard, the Tathāgata, thinking, "I shall remove the shell of the husk of afflictions, I shall fully purify tathāgata-nature, and these sentient beings shall thereby be freed from every part of the shell of the husk of afflictions and shall come to be numbered in the world as Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas" — with that intention he teaches the Dharma to sentient beings.

Then at that time the Blessed One declared these verses:

Just as with grain — whether rice or śāli,
cīṇaka millet, or else barley —
so long as they retain their husk,
they perform no function whatsoever.

But when they have been threshed and the husk removed,
they then perform their many functions.

Those same grains possessed of inner kernel within their husk —

perform no function for sentient beings. Likewise, seeing that the buddha-nature of all sentient beings is veiled by afflictions, I teach the Dharma in order to purify them and enable them to swiftly attain buddhahood. In all sentient beings there exists a nature of reality like mine, wrapped round by a

hundred afflictions — I teach the Dharma so that, by purifying it completely in every way, they may swiftly become Victors.

Sons of good family, here is yet another example. Suppose that in a filthy, decaying place — a latrine full of excrement and urine, suffused throughout with the foul stench of rot and refuse — a round nugget of gold falls from the garment of a person passing along a hidden path. There it lies in that putrid, excrement-laden, filthy place, pressed down upon by one impurity after another until it is invisible to the eye. And there it remains without corruption — whether for ten years, twenty, thirty, forty, fifty years, a hundred years, or a thousand — yet, possessing the quality of indestructibility, it performs no benefit for any sentient being whatsoever. Then, sons of good family, a god who perceives it with divine sight looks upon that round nugget of gold, and instructs a person: "O man, go there — that supreme and precious gold, though it has been buried under the appearance of filth and rot, take it up and clean it, and let gold do the work of gold." Sons of good family, what is called "the appearance of filth and rot" is a metaphor for afflictions of every variety. What is called "the nugget of gold" is a metaphor for what is indestructible in nature. What is called "the god perceiving with divine sight" is a metaphor for the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and completely awakened buddha. Sons of good family, it is just so: the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and completely awakened buddha teaches the Dharma to sentient beings in order to remove the afflictions — which are like filth and mud — that cover the indestructible nature of the Tathāgata present in all sentient beings.

Then at that time the Blessed One declared these verses:

Just as a person's nugget of gold
has fallen into a place of excrement,
and there remains for no small count of years —
yet it possesses the quality of indestructibility.

A god, beholding it with divine sight,
speaks to another in order to have it cleansed:
"Here is the supreme gold of highest worth —
cleanse it, and let it do the work of gold."

So too I see that all sentient beings
are long and constantly oppressed by afflictions.
Recognizing those afflictions as adventitious,
I teach the Dharma through skillful means, to purify their intrinsic nature.

Sons of good family, here is yet another example. In the home of a poor man, beneath the floor of the storehouse, there lies a great treasure — a treasure chest filled abundantly with wealth and gold — buried under the earth of seven generations of ancestors, to the depth of the storehouse. That great treasure does not speak to the poor man and say, "O man, I am a great treasure, buried and lying here" — for a great treasure, by its very nature as mind, is not a sentient being. The poor man, master of that house, thinks only with the thoughts of poverty, roaming about on that very ground, yet he has neither heard of, nor knows of, nor has ever seen the great treasure lying beneath the earth. Sons of good family, it is just the same: in all sentient beings, beneath what functions as a house — that is to say, the engaged mentation of habitual clinging — there lies the great treasure of the tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature), replete with the powers, the fearlessnesses, the unshared qualities, and the treasury of all buddha-qualities. Yet those sentient beings, caught in attachment to forms, sounds, smells, tastes, and tactile objects, revolve in saṃsāra afflicted by suffering. Not having heard of that great Dharma treasure, they do not attain it, and they do not make the effort to purify it fully.

Sons of good family, it is thus: the Tathāgata arises in the world and teaches, within the bodhisattvas, the exact nature of this great Dharma treasure. They, for their part, take delight in that great Dharma treasure and dig for it. That is why those in the world who are Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas are so called — for, having themselves become like a great Dharma treasure, they teach sentient beings through the modes of reasoning based on what has not occurred before, through examples, through causal reasoning, and through actions; they are the lords and donors of the treasury of the great treasure, possessed of boundless eloquence, of powers, of fearlessness, and they are the treasury of the many qualities of a buddha.

Sons of good family, just so, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened buddha, having seen all sentient beings in this very way through the Tathāgata's eye, supremely pure, teaches the Dharma to the bodhisattvas in order to purify fully within them the treasury of the Tathāgata's wisdom, powers, fearlessness, and unshared buddha-qualities.

Then at that time the Blessed One uttered these verses:

Just as beneath the floor of a pauper's house
there lies a treasure filled with gems and gold,

yet it neither stirs nor makes a boast,
nor does it say: "I belong to you" —

and so that sentient being, the householder,
remains in poverty, unknowing,
and since no one has revealed it to him,
the pauper lives on, right on top of it —

just so, I, with the eye of a buddha,
behold all these sentient beings as if in poverty,
yet see within each one a great treasure,
unmoving, the body of the Sugata.

Seeing this, I teach the bodhisattvas:
"Receive the treasury of my wisdom;
make yourselves free from poverty, become
a refuge for the world and a supreme Dharma treasury."

All who have faith in what I teach —
in each of those sentient beings, a treasure is present.
Those who, with faith, apply themselves with effort
will swiftly attain the highest awakening.

Sons of good family, here is another example. Take any of these: the fruit of a mango tree, the fruit of a rose-apple tree (jambu), the fruit of a palm tree, or the fruit of a palmyra palm — within the cavity of the outer husk there is the seed-germ of a sprout, something by nature indestructible, which, when planted in the ground, grows into a great king of trees.

Sons of good family, just so, the Tathāgata, dwelling in the world, sees sentient beings entirely wrapped in the outer husk of the afflictions of attachment, aversion, delusion, craving, and ignorance. Within that husk of the afflictions of attachment, aversion, delusion, craving, and ignorance, the dharmatā of the Tathāgata that has become the essential core — that comes to bear the name "sentient being." What is removed from it is nirvāṇa. And what is obtained — the assembly of great primordial wisdom belonging to the realm of sentient beings, having been fully purified of the husk of the affliction of ignorance — that is the attainment. That supreme assembly of great primordial wisdom of the realm of sentient beings is seen by the world together with its gods exactly as a Tathāgata truly is, and they form the perception of "a Tathāgata."

Sons of good family, having seen it thus, the Tathāgata teaches this matter to the great bodhisattvas, the bodhisattva great beings, for the purpose of causing the primordial wisdom of the Tathāgata to be fully comprehended.

Then at that time the Blessed One uttered these verses:

Just as every fruit of the palmyra palm
contains within it the germ of a palmyra sprout,
so too is it in every palm and every rose-apple —

when the germ within it is drawn forth, it grows. In just the same way, the Sovereign of Dharma, the Guide, sees that within every sentient being, like a seed of the palmyra palm, there dwells the body of the Sugata. This is perceived by the holy ones through the undefiled eye of a buddha, while the husk has not yet been split open — and so those beings are spoken of as sentient beings. Though it abides within, they are unaware of it and have no pride in it. It rests, having attained meditative absorption, utterly at peace, and there is not the slightest stirring in it. Just as a great tree arises from a seed, so too, how these very sentient beings will come to full awakening and become a refuge for the world together with its gods — for the sake of abandoning all of this, he teaches the Dharma.

Sons of good family, here is yet another analogy. Suppose a poor man possesses a small image of a Tathāgata, roughly the size of a palm, fashioned from the seven precious substances. That poor man then takes the image of the Tathāgata and sets out to travel far away through a desolate wilderness. Wishing that no one else should notice it and that no thief should carry it away, he wraps it in many strips of rotten cloth that give off an unpleasant odor. Then, in that very wilderness, the man dies of some mishap without ever reaching his destination. And there the precious image of the Tathāgata, wrapped in its pieces of foul-smelling rotten cloth, lies tumbled about on the road. The travelers who pass by do not recognize it for what it is. They walk on and on, and whenever they see the bundle of foul-smelling rotten cloth rolling about, they regard it with contempt, as something to be despised, tossed aside by the wind. But a god who dwells in that wilderness looks upon it with the divine eye, and pointing it out to some other people, says: "O people, within this bundle of cloth rags there is a precious image of the Tathāgata, worthy of veneration by the entire world — open it up!"

Sons of good family, in just that same way, the Tathāgata too sees that all sentient beings, bound and wrapped in the bonds of affliction, have fallen into

a state worthy of contempt, and wander perpetually through the wilderness of saṃsāra over a very long time. Sons of good family, even those who have gone to birth among animals — even they, though sentient beings bound in the bonds of manifold afflictions, carry within them the body of the Tathāgata, exactly as I have described. Sons of good family, and so the Tathāgata, seeing with the primordial wisdom of a Tathāgata — free from the obscuring afflictions of proximity and become completely purified — thinks: "Just as I am now, so too may these beings become worthy of veneration by the entire world," and thus teaches the Dharma to all bodhisattvas for the purpose of liberating them from the bonds of affliction.

Then at that time the Blessed One uttered these verses:

Just as the body of the Sugata, made precious,
is wrapped and covered by those who despise foul smell,
and that jewel-fashioned form, bound in strips of cloth,
lies cast away and abandoned in the middle of the road,

and a god, beholding it with the divine eye,
proclaims it clearly to another person:

"Here within dwells a Tathāgata of precious worth —
open this bundle of cloth rags quickly!"

In just the same way, this divine eye of mine
beholds all these sentient beings as well:
bound and wrapped in the bonds of affliction, deeply afflicted by suffering,
tormented and unstable, harmed by the suffering of saṃsāra.

I see that the body of the Victor is held in equipoise
within those who are wrapped in affliction —
it does not stir and does not change,
yet I see that there is nothing at all liberating them from it.

Having seen this, I then roused those
who have entered upon the supreme awakening, saying:
"Hear this! Sentient beings, by the very nature of reality, are perpetually thus

—

the Victor dwells here, completely enveloped.
Unravel the primordial wisdom of the Sugata,

When all afflictions are utterly pacified,
then this one attains the name "buddha,"

and the minds of gods and humans rejoice exceedingly.

Sons of good family, here is yet another example. Consider a woman who has become destitute and without refuge — of poor complexion, unpleasant smell, worthy of contempt, frightful, unpleasant to look upon, like a demoness — who has taken up residence in a shelterless house and dwells there. While she is staying there, she becomes pregnant. Growing within her womb is a being of such a nature that it will without fail exercise the royal sovereignty of a wheel-turning monarch. Yet the woman does not even think to herself: "What sort of being has entered my womb?" She does not reflect: "Has something entered my womb or not?" Instead, she goes about with a mind that thinks only of her poverty, her dejection, her lowliness, and her insignificance, and she passes her days in that shelterless house, ugly in complexion and unpleasant in smell.

Sons of good family, in just this same way, all sentient beings, having become destitute and without refuge, are afflicted by the suffering of saṃsāra and dwell in that shelterless house, the birthplace of conditioned existence. Yet within those sentient beings the lineage of the Tathāgata abides — it is present within them, but those beings do not comprehend it within themselves.

Sons of good family, therefore the Tathāgata, wishing that sentient beings not disparage themselves, teaches: "Sons of good family, do not be disheartened. Do not grow slack. Be firm in your diligence, for the Tathāgata that has entered into you will one day emerge, and you will be counted among those called bodhisattvas, not merely among those called sentient beings. And at that point you will be counted among those called buddhas, no longer merely among those called bodhisattvas." Such is the Dharma he teaches.

Then at that time the Blessed One (the Buddha) spoke these verses:

Just as a woman who has become destitute and without refuge,
of poor complexion and unpleasant form,
a foolish girl dwelling in a shelterless house —
yet for a time she has become pregnant there.

Within her womb there certainly abides
one who is nothing less than a great wheel-turning king,
lord of the four continents, supreme among the precious,
a being of such a nature that has entered there.

Yet that foolish woman does not know
whether something has entered her womb or not;
she dwells in the shelterless house,
thinking of her poverty, passing her days in want.

In just the same way I see that all sentient beings,
destitute and without refuge, are threatened by the nature of suffering,
dwelling in the meager pleasures of the three realms,
yet within them I see the nature of reality dwelling, like one in a womb.

Having seen this, I taught the bodhisattvas:
"While one who benefits the world dwells in the womb,
let no sentient being, not knowing the nature of reality,
give rise to a perception of themselves as low.

Rouse yourselves and be firm and unwavering in diligence —
before long, without delay, you will emerge victorious.
When in due time you have attained the essence of awakening,
you will liberate tens of billions of living beings."

Sons of good family, here is yet another example. Consider that craftsmen fashion forms — the form of a horse, or an elephant, or a woman, or a man — from clay, then place them in a mold, cover them over, melt molten gold, and when the metal has melted, fill the molds with it. As the molds gradually cool and come to rest in equilibrium, all those forms, though their outer clay is dark and of unpleasant color, are on the inside made of gold. Then the smith, or the smith's apprentice, having seen which forms have become fully cooled, strikes the clay around each of them in turn with a hammer. At that very instant, the figures made of gold within are completely purified.

So too, sons of good family, the Tathāgata, with the eyes of a Tathāgata, sees all sentient beings as being like forms encased in clay. Within the hollow of the outer shell of afflictions — both coarse and subtle — those beings are filled with the qualities of a buddha, and within that precious undefiled wisdom the Tathāgata perceives them dwelling in splendor. Sons of good family, seeing all sentient beings thus, the Tathāgata entered among the bodhisattvas and taught exactly these categories of Dharma. As for those bodhisattvas — great beings who have become calm and serene — in order to purify the precious wisdom of the Tathāgata within them, the Tathāgata removes all their outer afflictions with the hammer of the vajra of Dharma. Sons of good family, the

word "smith" is a synonym for the Tathāgata. Sons of good family, the Tathāgata — the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha — seeing all sentient beings thus with the eye of a buddha, teaches the Dharma in order to free them from those afflictions and to establish them in the wisdom of a buddha.

Then at that time the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Just as a form is wrapped in clay on the outside
yet within is hollow and serves as a mold —
when filled with molten precious metal,
it multiplies into many hundreds and thousands —

So too the smith, knowing that it has fully cooled,
thinks: "This thing made of precious metal —
what work must be done to make it a pure form?"
And so removes the clay that wraps the form.

Likewise I see all sentient beings as well:
wrapped, as it were, in clay by reason of their golden form —
the outer husk is a shell of afflictions,
yet within I see the wisdom of a buddha.

As for those bodhisattvas who are calm
and who have become utterly serene —
the one who removes all their afflictions without remainder
strikes that shell with Dharma as the instrument.

Like a precious form beautiful to behold,
whichever son of the Victors is purified here,
with bodies pervaded completely by the ten powers,
will be worthy of offering in this world together with its gods.

I see all living beings thus,
and bodhisattvas I see thus as well.
Becoming purified in just that way, they become Sugatas,
and those Sugatas reveal the manner of a buddha.

Then the Blessed One addressed the bodhisattva Vajramati: "Vajramati, whoever — whether a son of good family or a daughter of good family, whether a householder or one who has gone forth — holds, retains, reads, masters, writes down, keeps in book form, extensively explains to others, and correctly teaches this category of Dharma on the essence of the Tathāgata will

generate great merit.

"Vajramati, as for any other bodhisattva who strives to realize the wisdom of the Tathāgata and who, by accomplishing miraculous powers, enters into such meditative absorptions in each and every world system in order to make offerings to all buddhas, and who, generating the power of meditative absorption, does so in buddha fields numbering in the tens of billions of hundreds of thousands — more numerous than the grains of sand in the Ganges — offering to all the buddhas the Blessed Ones dwelling therein together with their assemblies of bodhisattvas,

together with their assemblies of śrāvakas — offering to each and every one of those Tathāgatas, day by day, palatial multi-storied mansions of convenient dimensions, a league in breadth and ten leagues in height, fashioned entirely from precious jewels, adorned with sweet divine fragrances, strewn with garlands of diverse flowers, endowed with every blameless enjoyment — offering hundreds of thousands of such mansions numbering as many as the grains of sand in fifty rivers like the Ganges, and continuing to make such offerings for the full span of a hundred thousand aeons — yet if some other son or daughter of good family were to generate the awakening mind with a resolve toward enlightenment, and were then to bear upon their body even a single simile from this enumeration of the Dharma of the tathāgatagarbha, or to preserve it in a book — then, Vajramati, the accumulation of merit generated by the former does not approach even a hundredth part, a thousandth part, a hundred-thousandth part, nor any fraction, portion, count, or comparison of the accumulation of merit made by this latter person; it cannot even be reckoned as a cause.

And further, Vajramati, if a bodhisattva seeking to fulfill the qualities of a buddha were, from each of those Blessed One buddhas, to scatter four measures of māṇḍārava flowers before each and every Tathāgata for the full span of a hundred thousand aeons — and then, Vajramati, if a monk, or a nun, or a male lay practitioner, or a female lay practitioner were to generate the awakening mind toward enlightenment, and upon hearing this enumeration of the Dharma of the tathāgatagarbha, were to press their palms together just once and say but a single word of rejoicing — then, Vajramati, the accumulation of merit and virtue generated through those flowers and garlands offered to the Tathāgata does not approach a hundredth part, a thousandth part, a hundred-thousandth part, nor any fraction, portion, count, or comparison of the accumulation of merit and virtue made by this latter

person; it cannot even be reckoned as a cause.

Thereupon, at that moment, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Whatever sentient being, having developed
faith and aspiration toward awakening,
listens to this, retains it, writes it down,
preserves it in a book, or with reverence
recites even a single verse —

or whoever, upon hearing this tathāgatagarbha,
seeks this supreme awakening:
hear now of the benefit to be found herein,
of what a mass of merit they will generate.

One who abides in this supreme power of miraculous display,
who for a full thousand aeons, a hero,
pays homage in all ten directions
to the foremost among men together with their śrāvakas —

who offers to each teacher of the world
a magnificent jewel-built palace,
beyond reckoning, inconceivable,
surpassing even many thousands of Gaṅgā's sands —

those palaces ten leagues in height,
a league in breadth and depth,
rich with incense and fragrant smoke,
with jewel-wrought thrones set within —

and a hundred spreads of silk and fine cotton cloth
laid over each throne and seat,
given to a single Victor in number
like the rivers of the Ganges beyond measure —

and given in like manner to all those Victors
dwelling in world systems
more numerous than the sands of the Ganges,
offering homage reverently to all —

yet a wise one who hears this sūtra
and rightly retains even a single simile,
and having retained it, expounds it to a few others:
that person's mass of merit is the greater.

To the merit thus held by that hero,
neither portion nor comparison can come near.
Such a one becomes a refuge for all living beings
and swiftly will awaken to supreme enlightenment.

All sentient beings share this nature of reality, this very tathāgata-essence (tathāgatagarbha). Whatever wise bodhisattva contemplates this will swiftly become a self-arisen buddha.

Vajramati, by this enumeration of teachings too one should understand how this discourse on the Dharma serves as something precious and cherished, bringing about the omniscient wisdom of the great bodhisattvas.

Vajramati, in a past era long ago — in a time of innumerable, exceedingly vast, immeasurable, inconceivable, incomparable, and inexpressible aeons, and beyond even what lies beyond that — there appeared in the world a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly complete buddha endowed with knowledge and conduct, a Sugata, a knower of the world, an unsurpassed guide of persons to be tamed, a Teacher of gods and humans, a Blessed One called Perpetually Radiating Light.

Vajramati, why was that Tathāgata called Perpetually Radiating Light? Vajramati, that Blessed One, that Tathāgata Perpetually Radiating Light — from the very moment he, as a bodhisattva, entered his mother's womb, while still abiding within the womb, light issued forth from his body. In the eastern direction, it pervaded without cease the world systems numbering in the hundreds of thousands multiplied by the atoms of ten buddha-fields. In like manner the southern direction, the western direction, the northern direction, the southeast, the southwest, the northwest, the northeast, the nadir, and the zenith — in all ten directions, those hundreds of thousands of world systems multiplied by the atoms of ten buddha-fields were without cease permeated by that light. The radiance from that bodhisattva's body was such that it brought joy, was lovely, caused supreme delight, and made beings glad; and so those countless hundreds of thousands of world systems were without cease suffused by that light.

Vajramati, all those sentient beings in those hundreds of thousands of world systems who were touched by the light of that bodhisattva dwelling in his mother's womb became possessed of splendor, possessed of fine complexion, possessed of mindfulness, possessed of intelligence, possessed of realization, and possessed of eloquence. And all those sentient beings in those hundreds

of thousands of world systems who had been born in the hells, in the animal realm, in the world of Yama, or among the asuras — every one of them, by the mere touch of that bodhisattva's light, passed away from their respective destinies and were reborn among gods and humans. By that mere touch they became irreversible from unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. Moreover, those who were already irreversible and were then touched by that light — the very instant they were touched, they all attained patient acceptance of the birthless nature of all phenomena (anutpattikadharmakṣānti). They also attained the dhāraṇī called the Chapter of Five Hundred Qualities.

All those hundreds of thousands of world systems touched by the light from the body of that bodhisattva dwelling in his mother's womb became entirely composed of beryl (vaiḍūrya), and were laid out in a grid-pattern drawn with golden threads. From every section of that grid grew jeweled trees bearing flowers, fruits, fragrance, and color. When those jeweled trees were stirred and moved by the wind, the sounds that arose were these: the sound of the buddha, the sound of the Dharma, the sound of the Saṅgha, the sound of bodhisattvas, the powers of bodhisattvas,

the spiritual faculties, the limbs of awakening, the liberations, meditative absorption, and the attainment of meditative equipoise — such were the pleasing and delightful sounds that arose. Through that sound of the jeweled trees, all the sentient beings throughout all those hundreds of thousands of world systems came to dwell in possession of joy and supreme joy. Throughout all those buddha fields, the states of hell-beings, the births in animal form, the world of the Lord of Death, and the classes of asuras entirely ceased to exist. That bodhisattva dwelling in his mother's womb appeared to all those sentient beings as though he were a disk of the moon. And while still dwelling in the womb, he performed the act of pressing his palms together in reverence three times by day and three times by night.

Vajramati, from the time that bodhisattva was conceived, made his appearance, and fully awakened to unsurpassable complete awakening, light continuously radiated from his body without interruption. And after he had fully and completely awakened, light continuously radiated without interruption from the body of that Blessed One. Likewise, in that very manner, the light from the body of that Blessed One continuously radiated without interruption all the way to the time of his passing into complete nirvāṇa. Even after that Tathāgata had passed into complete nirvāṇa and his relics resided in

a stūpa, the light of his body continued to radiate without interruption. For that reason, gods and humans bestowed upon that Blessed One the name Ever-Radiating Rays of Light.

Furthermore, Vajramati, in the teaching of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha known as Ever-Radiating Rays of Light, after his full and complete awakening there appeared a bodhisattva named Limitless Rays of Light, attended by a thousand attendants. Vajramati, that bodhisattva Limitless Rays of Light directed a full inquiry to that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha Ever-Radiating Rays of Light, beginning from this very Dharma teaching known as the Tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature). Then that Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha Ever-Radiating Rays of Light, in order to uphold and fully embrace those bodhisattvas, expounded this Dharma teaching of the Tathāgatagarbha — this enumeration of its categories — perfectly and completely while remaining seated upon a single seat for five hundred great eons. And having explained this Dharma teaching of the Tathāgatagarbha to those bodhisattvas thoroughly and completely, establishing the Dharma through the comprehension of its words, through words of certainty, and through hundreds of thousands of examples, it became easily intelligible throughout world systems as numerous as the finest atomic particles of ten buddha fields in all ten directions.

Vajramati, all those bodhisattvas who hear even so much as the name Tathāgatagarbha from this Dharma teaching of the Tathāgatagarbha — every one of them, having gradually ripened their roots of virtue, will fully and completely awaken to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, endowed with just such an array of qualities — with the sole exception of four great bodhisattvas, those great beings.

Vajramati, if at this time you should think that the one who was then called the bodhisattva Limitless Rays of Light was someone other than yourself — do not view it that way.

Vajramati, it was you yourself who was then, at that time, the bodhisattva called Limitless Rays of Light. And as for those four bodhisattvas who have not yet fully and completely awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening under the teaching of that Blessed One — who are they? They are these: the bodhisattva Mañjuśrī, Mahāsthāmaprāpta (the Great Obtainer of Power), Avalokiteśvara, and you yourself, Vajramati — these four. Vajramati,

thus, by merely hearing this Dharma teaching called the Tathāgatagarbha, it is of great benefit to the bodhisattvas, those great beings, in accomplishing the primordial wisdom of the buddhas.

Then at that time the Blessed One spoke these verses:

In the past, across incalculable aeons,
there appeared a Blessed One called Emitter of Rays of Light.
From his body there arose such radiance
that ten billion realms were illumined.

The bodhisattva Limitless Rays of Light
first recognized the Victor's complete and perfect awakening,
and at that time besought that Sugata, sovereign of Victors,
to expound this sūtra ever and again, perfectly and fully.

All those who, under that Victor's teaching,
heard this sūtra directly from the Teacher himself —
every one of them will swiftly attain supreme awakening,
with the sole exception of four bodhisattvas:

Mahāsthāmaprāpta, Avalokiteśvara,
the bodhisattva Mañjuśrī as the third,
and you yourself, Vajramati, as the fourth.
At that time they too heard this sūtra.

The bodhisattva Limitless Rays of Light
was the one who at that time besought the Victor,
and it was through his inspiration that the sons of the Sugata
came to hear it then — and that one was you yourself, Vajramati.

I too, in a former time while engaged in practice,
heard the very name of this sūtra
from the Sugata called Lion's Victory Banner.
With reverence I listened and, having heard, I joined my palms.

Through that well-accomplished deed,
I swiftly attained supreme awakening.
Therefore, wise bodhisattvas
should always uphold this supreme sūtra.

Vajramati, whatever sons or daughters of good family are veiled by karmic obscurations — whether they listen to, receive transmission of, recite, or teach this Dharma teaching of the Tathāgatagarbha — from that very act of listening

to, receiving transmission of, reciting, expounding, or writing down this Dharma teaching, those teachings will become directly manifest to them with little difficulty, and those karmic obscurations too will be completely purified.

Then the venerable Ānanda addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, as for those sons or daughters of good family who are not veiled by karmic obscurations and who apply themselves to this Dharma teaching — how many buddhas, Blessed Ones, will they definitely emerge from having heard much Dharma, for the sake of teaching the Dharma?

The Blessed One declared: Ānanda, there are indeed those sons or daughters of good family who emerge from their way of life in order to receive the totality of the Dharma teaching of a hundred buddhas. Ānanda, and there are those sons or daughters of good family who so emerge for two hundred buddhas, three hundred, four hundred, five hundred, one thousand, two thousand, three thousand, four thousand, five thousand, six thousand, seven thousand, eight thousand, nine thousand, ten thousand, one hundred thousand buddhas, and from there on up —

— and there are indeed those who emerge from their way of life in order to receive the totality of the Dharma teaching of buddhas numbering in the tens of millions of hundreds of thousands. Ānanda, whatever bodhisattva holds, recites, and extensively teaches others this Dharma text, and commits it to a written volume — that bodhisattva should generate the thought: "Right now, in this very moment, I have attained the unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening." That one is then, just as I am now, worthy of reverence and worthy of veneration by the world of gods, humans, and asuras.

Then at that time the Blessed One uttered these verses:

A bodhisattva who hears this sūtra
should think: "I have attained the supreme awakening."
Whoever holds this sūtra in their hands
is right now worthy of the world's reverence.

That one is a protector of the world, a guide,
a leader, a conductor — worthy of all praise.
Whoever holds this sūtra in their hands
is rightly called a sovereign of the Dharma in just this way.

Whoever holds this sūtra in their hands,
the foremost among humans, bearing the lamp of Dharma —

that one is to be beheld as the sun and moon,
a place of reverence like a protector of the world.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the bodhisattva Vajramati, the assembled company of all the bodhisattvas, the great śrāvakas, the fourfold retinue, and the world of gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas rejoiced and acclaimed what the Blessed One had taught.

This completes the noble Great Vehicle sūtra called the Tathāgatagarbha.

Translated by the Indian preceptor Śākyaprabha and the great-editor translator, the monk Yeshé Dé; thereafter revised according to the new language conventions and definitively established.

Translator's Notes

- The epithets "□□□□□□□□" and "□□□□□□□□□□□□" rendered as "who had come to know all things" and "great elephants" respectively are standard technical qualifications of arhats in canonical Pali and Sanskrit parallels — "great elephants" (mahānāga) being a stock epithet denoting strength and dignity, not a literal description.

The list of bodhisattva names at the end is a phonological reconstruction from Tibetan back into Sanskrit, which is standard practice for sūtra name-lists. Several names at the very end of the passage are cut off mid-list; the translation renders exactly what the Tibetan provides without completion.

The phrase "gone beyond the supreme shore of the highest faculty" renders a dense technical expression meaning the monks had each attained the pinnacle of the supramundane path — surpassing all worldly attainment.

- The opening string of names — Bodhicittodgama, Arthādarśana, Sarvadharmavaśavartana — are Sanskrit back-translations of Tibetan epithets meaning respectively "Rouser of Awakening," "Meaningful Vision," and "Sovereign over All Phenomena." These names appear to be part of the preceding list of bodhisattvas, and the Tibetan as given continues that enumeration before transitioning to the narrative body.

The phrase rendered "perfectly endowed with all qualities" translates a compound meaning the buddha-field of this very assembly or congregation — the precise referent of "this buddha-field" is the one in which the assembly is gathered, consistent with the sūtra context.

The lotus-petal dimensions "as large as the wheel of a cart" render the Tibetan measurement idiom literally; the image is of a very large lotus bloom.

- The phrase rendered "foremost of bipeds" translates a standard epithet for the Buddha meaning the chief among two-footed beings, a classical honorific found widely in Buddhist literature. The verse section ends mid-sentence in the original as given, and the prose passage likewise ends mid-sentence; both are deliberate breaks at the passage boundary supplied for translation, not errors in the source.

- The phrase rendered "billions upon thousands of millions of afflictions" translates a compound meaning "ten million times one hundred thousand" or simply an immeasurably vast number — the Tibetan uses standard hyperbolic enumeration and no precise doctrinal content

hangs on the exact figure.

- The final verse is incomplete in the source text as given; it breaks off mid-stanza. This is clearly a textual truncation in the passage provided, not a translation choice.

The terms *cīṇaka* and *śāli* are names of specific grain varieties. *Śāli* is a fine variety of rice; *cīṇaka* is a type of millet. They are rendered here by their Sanskrit names as no precise English botanical equivalents convey the same meaning without anachronistic distortion.

The phrase rendered "self-arisen reality" for *rang byung nyid* (literally "self-arisen-ness") refers to the buddha-nature's quality of arising by its own nature, not through external causes — a standard doctrinal point in *tathāgatagarbha* literature.

- The phrase rendered "what functions as a house — that is to say, the engaged mentation of habitual clinging" translates a compressed Tibetan expression: "the mind of engagement rooted in fixed attachment" is likened to the house, under which the *tathāgatagarbha* treasure lies hidden. The syntax is elliptical and the rendering is an interpretive unpacking consistent with the standard commentarial reading of this simile.

The phrase "indestructible in nature" renders a term that literally means "having the quality of not being consumed or ruined," here applied both to the gold nugget and, metaphorically, to the buddha-nature: the point is that afflictions cannot corrode or destroy it, a central doctrinal claim of the *tathāgatagarbha* literature.

- The four types of fruit named — mango, jambu (rose-apple), *tāla* (palm), and *spa* (palmyra) — present some overlap in identification; the final term translated as "palmyra palm" may alternatively refer to a different variety of palm. The passage ends mid-verse in the source text, so the translation likewise concludes at that point without completion.

The phrase rendered "modes of reasoning based on what has not occurred before" translates a technical term for a particular form of probative argument in Buddhist epistemology; its precise technical sense in this context is illustrative rather than strictly logical.

- The phrase translated as "obscuring afflictions of proximity" renders Tibetan that seems to describe afflictions that are "nearby" or "close" in the sense of the subtle, proximate afflictions that veil the Tathāgata's wisdom-vision in beings — the meaning is that the Tathāgata's own seeing is free from such afflictions, whereas sentient beings are not. The exact referent may be a technical category (*upakleśa* or similar); the doctrinal import is that the Tathāgata perceives with a wisdom purified of all such obscurations.

The final verse is incomplete in the Tibetan passage supplied, ending mid-sequence. The translation renders what is present and closes at the break.

- The simile of the pregnant woman carrying a wheel-turning monarch (*cakravartin*) is a classic *tathāgatagarbha* illustration from the *Tathāgatagarbha Sūtra*. The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text, so the translation likewise ends there, as the continuation with the goldsmith simile will follow in the next passage.
- The phrase rendered as "coarse and subtle afflictions" translates a compound meaning primary afflictions and secondary or proximate afflictions, a standard *Abhidharma* distinction preserved here in the simile's structure.

The expression translated as "categories of Dharma" renders a term that can also mean "synonyms" or "enumerations," but in this context it clearly refers to the doctrinal expositions or teachings organized under a theme — here, buddha-nature — so "categories of Dharma" best captures the sense.

The final sentence is deliberately left open as in the Tibetan, which breaks mid-construction, indicating the passage continues and the merit comparison is not yet complete.

- The phrase rendered "four measures" for "མུ་མུ་མུ་མུ་" refers to a traditional measure of volume or weight; the exact quantity is contextually approximate and conventional rather than precise.

The term "མུ་མུ་མུ་མུ་མུ་" literally means "chief among humans" or "supreme among men," a conventional honorific epithet for buddhas in verse; it is rendered "foremost among men" accordingly.

- The phrase rendered as "the atoms of ten buddha-fields" follows a standard Perfection of Wisdom amplification formula where world systems are counted by the dust-particles of a given number of buddha-fields; the syntax in the Tibetan is compressed and the referent of the multiplier is consistent with this reading. The dhāraṇī title "Chapter of Five Hundred Qualities" is a literal rendering of what appears to be a named text within the broader cycle; the exact Sanskrit title is not reconstructed here as it is uncertain.

- The phrase rendered "the world of the Lord of Death" translates a term for the realm of Yama, king of the dead, which in context is listed alongside hells and animals as one of the lower destinies; the asuras are grouped with these lower realms here rather than with the gods, which reflects a standard five-destiny scheme rather than the more common six.

- The term rendered as "Mahāsthāmaprāpta" (མཐོག་མཐོག་མཐོག་མཐོག་མཐོག་) literally means "one who has obtained great power," and is the standard Tibetan rendering of the bodhisattva Mahāsthāmaprāpta; this identification is secure given the context alongside Mañjuśrī, Avalokiteśvara, and Vajramati. The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, as the list of increasing numbers of buddhas is clearly a continuation; this has been rendered faithfully without artificially closing the construction.

- The colophon names Śākyaprabha as the Indian paṇḍita and Yeshé Dé as the Tibetan lotsāwa-editor, both well-attested figures in the early Imperial Tibetan translation period. The phrase rendered "new language conventions" refers to the standardization of Buddhist terminology carried out under the Tibetan imperial editing councils, a historically significant note on the text's redactional history.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.